



To many people, Petrarch is known as the "father of humanism."



This mural features Timur Leng, who rose from humble beginnings to found the Timurid dynasty after outmatching the conquests of Genghis Khan.



Constructed of brick and timber, the Bell Tower of Xi'an was built during the early Ming dynasty, in the reign of Zhu Yuanzhang, the first Ming emperor.



BOHEMIA HAD EMERGED AS A POWERFUL STATE under the Premyslid dynasty in the 13th century. Under the **Luxembourg dynasty**, it became the central force in German imperial geopolitics, while its ruler **Charles I** (Charles IV as Holy Roman Emperor) sought to **modernize** the imperial institution and advance the fortunes of Bohemia. In 1348, he had enlarged the kingdom by **granting it territories** such as Moravia and Silesia, and refounded **Prague** to become one of the foremost cities in Europe, with a major university. In 1356, Charles IV issued the **Golden Bull**, which regularized the election of the emperor to a majority vote of seven electoral princes, most of which were hereditary; the papacy would have no role. This, in turn, allowed the electoral principalities to develop **sovereign states**, and set the constitutional basis of the Holy Roman Empire until its final

Golden Bull
Edicts issued with golden seals were called **Golden Bulls**. That of Emperor Charles IV sought to prevent future imperial elections from descending into conflict.



dissolution in 1806. The Bull established Bohemia as first among the electors and guaranteed its independence.

Timur Leng (1336–1405)—also known as Tamerlane—rose from modest beginnings to become leader of a **Turkic-Mongol Chagatai tribe** in Transoxiana, Central Asia, in around 1362. Despite having a limp, and the fact that he was not of **Chinggid descent** (directly descended from Genghis Khan—only Chinggids could become khans), he was destined to become one of the **greatest conquerors** in history.

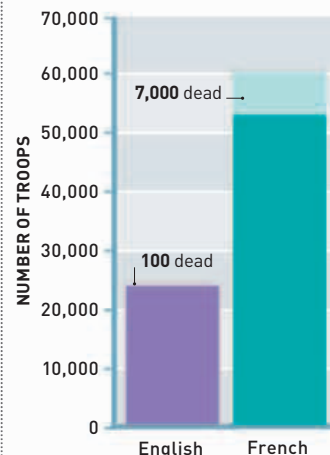
Edward of Woodstock, eldest son of Edward III, also known as the **Black Prince** (1330–76), had won his spurs at the **Battle of Crécy** at age 16. He went on to become one of the most effective English commanders. When **hostilities renewed** between England and France in 1355, he invaded France, winning a great victory near **Poitiers** in 1356, in which he captured **King John of France**.

EDWARD, THE BLACK PRINCE, HAD BEEN MADE PRINCE OF GASCONY AND AQUITAINE in 1362, moving to Bordeaux and becoming a major player in continental affairs. In 1367, he intervened in a **dynastic dispute in Castile**, where French ally Henry of Trastámara (1334–79) had deposed English ally Pedro I, thereby **placing control of the Castilian navy in the French camp**. Edward defeated Henry at **Nájera** but was forced to withdraw owing to illness. Subsequently, Henry regained the Castilian throne. In 1372—after **Charles V of France** (r. 1364–80) had fomented a **Gascon rebellion**, restarting the **Hundred Years' War**—the Castilian navy proved instrumental in defeating an English fleet at **La Rochelle**.

China was reunited by conquest from the south, as a native rebellion drove out the **Mongol Yuan dynasty**. In 1368, rebels under **Zhu Yuanzhang** (1328–98)—a former peasant turned Buddhist monk then general—struck north from their base in Nanjing, **displacing the Yuan from Beijing**. Taking the imperial name **Hongwu**, Yuanzhang established the **Ming dynasty**, setting up a strong, centralized government, in which the position of emperor was strengthened, but so was access to the bureaucracy. In 1372, he passed an edict attempting to ban maritime trade and thus **limit contact with foreigners**.

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Under **Murad I** (r. 1362–89), the Ottoman Turks extended their control deep into the **Balkans**. In 1371, Murad defeated an alliance of Serbs, Byzantines, and Bulgars, and held control over much of Thrace, Macedonia, Bulgaria, and Serbia. He also created the **janissaries**, a slave-warrior corps that became the mainstay of Ottoman armies.



Battle of Nájera
Outnumbered by almost three to one, the English-Gascon army defeated the French-Castilian forces with the loss of only around 100 men.

1354 Venetian fleet defeats Genoese at **Porto Longo**
1354 **Mohammed V** becomes king of Granada and develops the **Alhambra palace**
1355 **Stephen Dushan**, king of Serbia, dies; his empire starts to disintegrate
1355 **Nationalist revolt** against Mongol rule gathers pace in **China**

1356 **Anti-Mongol Chinese rebels seize Nanjing**
1359 Civil war in the **Golden Horde**, Eastern Europe
1360 **Edward III** campaigns in France, and agrees terms at the **Treaty of Calais**
1360 **Golden Bull** of Emperor **Charles IV**

1362 **Algirdas of Lithuania** defeats the Mongols and extends his territories to **Black Sea**
c. 1362 **Timur Leng** emerges as tribal leader in **Transoxiana**, Central Asia
1364 **Casimir the Great** of Poland founds a school at **Cracow**

1367 **Battle of Nájera**
1368 **Zhu Yuanzhang** expels Yuan dynasty and founds **Ming dynasty**
1368 **Tibet** regains independence following Yuan collapse
1369 **Timur Leng** conquers **Samarqand**

1369 **Hanseatic League** at peak of its power
1371 **Battle of Chernomen**
1372 French are victorious in naval battle of **La Rochelle**, and recover **Poitiers**